endeavours are aimed at asserting control by subjugating others. Reality, however, rarely reaches that level. It is more often expressed as acquiring and sharpening instruments of influence. In a way, it is work continuously in progress. The more dominant nations, by definition, are more active in offense while the vast majority are focussed mainly on defence. Creating a global order is one outcome of this exercise since it establishes mechanisms that regulate behaviour and legitimize demands. Depending on the domain, standards can have great utility by making the capabilities of a few the aspirations of many.

In the evolution of societies, progress in the security world and that in everyday life have always been connected to each other. Advances in one are naturally transposed on the other, whether we speak of materials, communication, platforms or activities. What has often begun in laboratories or businesses has ended up in armouries. Equally, commercializing security inventions or discoveries has been successful over the ages. However, as the world has become more globalized, the lines separating the two are becoming fainter. Some of this reflects the more integrated nature of technology; others derive from a deliberate civil–military fusion. In some nations, in a situation where less is taken at face value, we must be aware that economic activities cannot only enhance security capabilities but can even be driven by them. Where business ends and security begins is no longer easy to distinguish.

Behaviour, too, can be shaped by setting norms and establishing etiquette. That is why rule-making and rule-observance have become so central to debates in international politics today. But the rules of the game are often inadequate to either advance interests or establish an effective defence. It becomes even more complicated when the rules are non-existent, disputed or simply disregarded. Therefore, serious polities naturally concentrate on building capabilities rather than assuming intent. India, too, must recognize clearly that the former can be insurance on the latter. The basis for assured security lies in deeper strengths, a realization that has separated the bigger powers from the rest.

This is particularly pertinent to India because our industrial and manufacturing capacities have not kept pace with the overall growth. Even as we endeavour to introduce corrections, the logic for advocating rules and norms remains generally strong. In the foreseeable future, we are more likely to be injured than to gain from their absence. Smaller nations that do